



Broad Band!

If your dial-up connection is the story of the tortoise that loses, brace yourself for the hare that wins

Urmila Rane

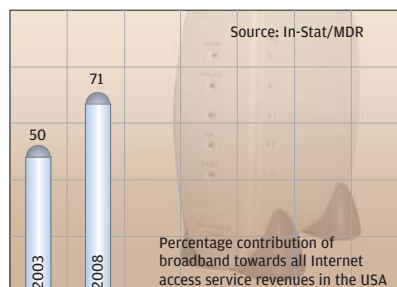
You know how it is. You dial-up connection sucks. Your throughput rate, on a very very good day, is 40 Kbps. Your friends who use a CDMA phone to connect to the Net get around twice that speed, and your friends in the US and Europe get around 100 times that speed on a bad day. Sigh!

Dial-up is still the commonest way to access the Internet in India even today. Even if "broadband" has been around for some time now, speeds have been pathetic if the service is priced low, and if you want high speeds, you had to pay through your nose. Result? Broadband never even took off even if there was huge demand from both corporates and individuals alike.

Today

Cut to 20 December, 2004. India's largest fixed-line telecommunications companies MTNL and BSNL announce that both will provide connection speeds of a minimum of 256 Kbps at just Rs 500 per month starting January 15 from the existing Rs 3,000, effectively cutting down your Internet access costs by a sixth.

So is it time to say that broadband has finally arrived? Going by the frenetic pace at which every telecom company worth its salt is getting into the broadband arena, it sure would seem so!



The government, too, has realised the importance of broadband, and has actively delicensed the 2.4 to 2.48 GHz band for low-power outdoor use. Simultaneously, the Department of Telecommunication (DoT), in its new broadband policy released on 14 October, 2004, defined broadband as Internet connection speed at a minimum of 256 Kbps, up from the regular "up to 128 Kbps" speeds given by leading Internet service providers in the country. This means that no ISP can advertise its services as broadband if download speeds are below 256 Kbps.

It was about time. Take these figures. While there were 123 million broadband connections by 2004 worldwide, India had only 1.2 lakh. Of the 123 million, the United States has 29 million, China 19 million, Japan 16 million, South Korea 12 million and Canada 5 million. Evidently, India has a long way to go. And the Indian user would want that journey to begin fast. Really fast.

That journey could well begin now. If both BSNL and MTNL live up to their 256-Kbps-at-Rs 500-a-month promise, broadband use could see a sudden surge even if many would say the scenario should have played out a long time ago.

What You Can Expect In 2005

MTNL will be launching its new Rs 500-a-month scheme in Delhi and Mumbai on January 15, while BSNL will launch it in Kolkata, Bangalore, Chennai and Hyderabad the same day.

Says Sandeep Kolwadkar, deputy general manager, business development, BSNL: "Our priority is to provide broadband services this year at affordable prices. For this we have invested Rs 600 crore in 198 cities across India. We have implemented copper loop access technology along with other technologies. We possess a huge